



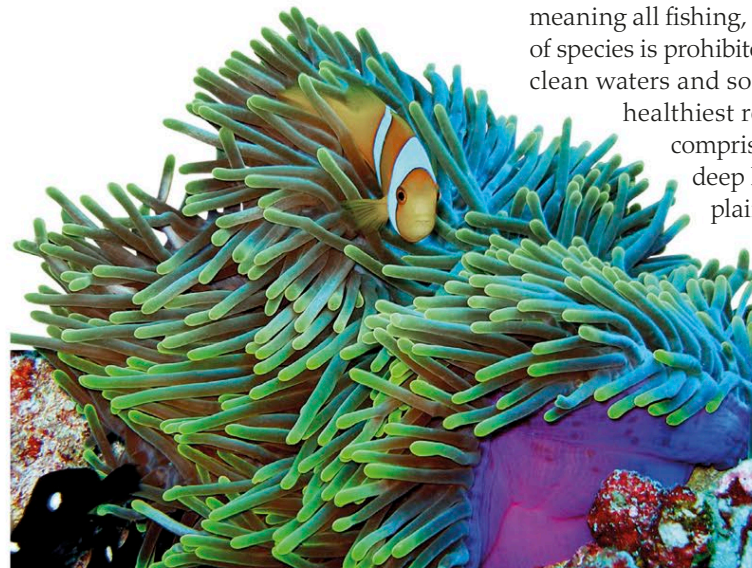
The Great Chagos Bank

The largest coral atoll on the planet, surrounded by some of the cleanest waters in the world



Located a few hundred miles south of the Maldives (see below), the Great Chagos Bank is Earth's largest coral atoll in terms of area, although most of its 4,880 square miles (12,640 square km) lie underwater. Just 2.2 square miles (5.6 square km) of the

bank's eight islands form low-lying sandy beaches, some covered with coconut palms and bushy vegetation. The bank is part of the vast Chagos Marine Reserve (247,100 square miles / 640,000 square km), which is a "no-take" marine protected area, meaning all fishing, netting, and removing of species is prohibited. With its extremely clean waters and some of the world's healthiest reef systems, and comprising seamounts and deep knolls as well as shallow plains, Chagos is one of the world's richest marine environments.



< MARINE REFUGE
More than 220 species of corals make up the Great Chagos Bank, creating a reef habitat for around 800 fish species, including anemonefish.

▽ RACE TO THE SEA

Bird Island is a center of wildlife conservation. Here, endangered hawksbill and green sea turtles lay their eggs, which are protected until they hatch. The hatchlings then head out to sea.



The Maldives

Asia's smallest country, with more than 1,000 low-lying islands, all at the mercy of the sea



Around 1,190 live coral reefs and sandbar islands make up the double chain of atolls of the tropical Maldives, off the southwestern coast of India. The island count fluctuates, because the Maldives has the lowest sea level of any country. With an average elevation of just 6 ft (1.8m) above sea level, islands come and go as sea level and climate change. All are projections of the underwater Chagos Laccadive volcanic mountain range. Within each atoll are up to 10 inhabited islands and up to 60 uninhabited ones, most with white sandy beaches that are important nesting grounds for green sea turtles.



△ GLOWING TIDE

Bioluminescent plankton light up the surf as waves wash ashore in the Maldives. Marine life in the area ranges from microscopic organisms to whale sharks.